

My situation – and my attitude – was not unlike an addiction. I was abusing money. I had tried to correct the debt, and I paid down the first \$7000 after an initial budget was put in place; but instead of cutting up the card when the balance hit zero, I hit the boutiques and bars again.

By late 2014, I'd given away fashion journalism and joined *Domain* as a property reporter, but I was still living week to week. Having a consistently low bank balance was leaving me feeling as empty as the bottom of one too many glasses of pinot after another expensive night out. As my early 30s ticked over, friends walked down the aisle, welcomed babies and bought homes. The only aisle I was walking down was at the liquor shop on a Friday night.

But working as a property journalist opened my eyes to another big-ticket investment – property, not Prada. Perhaps because I'm a member of Gen Y – the want-it-now generation – my shift in priorities happened quite suddenly. Reporting on a weekend auction for *Domain*, I watched with envy as a young couple embraced and wept as the hammer fell on their dream apartment. I was more jealous of that than any outfit I'd seen on a runway or in a magazine. The immense pleasure they got from that purchase was meaningful in a way that my spending wasn't. Their emotion was contagious. Back in the car I teared up, moved by their joy and sense of achievement, which grated against my growing feeling that I had indulged in superficial habits for too long.

My parents, with whom I am close, had no idea of my financial situation. I came clean to them about my credit card debt and, given my parents are excellent at budgeting, together we devised a strategy. We set what appeared to be an iron-fisted budget, siphoning my salary into categories for rent, bills, groceries, clothing, recreation and debt repayments, all managed by me, and with the strictest of intent. But I failed to adhere to it – my shaky self-esteem and fashion addiction were still my undoing.

It took several more months for me to admit to them that I'd again stuffed up, and worse than ever. If I was treading water before, now I was sinking. When I went shopping with Mum, she thought my splurges were occasional treats on this new budget, unaware that, as the unpaid bills had accumulated, I'd started to withdraw cash against my credit card at a heart-stopping 20-per-cent-plus interest. It was a secret. My family never saw how much I cried.